St. Joseph's Anglo-Chinese School
Form 5 English Language
Paper 2 Writing – DSE 2022 Paper 2 (Part B): Learning from a sample script

Learning from a sample script — how a Level 5** script handles *content* and *organisation* (60-minute lesson)

Part 1: plan the task and the content (15 min) • Part 2: read the sample and see what it does with content and organisation (30 min) • Part 3: comment, score and write (15 min)

TEACHER'S VERSION — answers, teaching notes and timings in red. Students' version = this file with every red item removed.

PART 1: BEFORE YOU WRITE — READ THE QUESTION AND PLAN THE CONTENT (15 minutes)

1. The question

The School Management is considering a four-day school week. Students would only need to attend school four days a week instead of five, but the length of each day would be increased by one hour.

You are a member of the Parent-Teacher Association (PTA). Write a letter to the President of the PTA stating your opinion either for or against a four-day school week. Give reasons to support your view.

(DSE 2022 English Language Paper 2, Part B, Question 9 — 'Learning English through Debating'. Reproduced from the question paper.)

Teaching note: *3 minutes. Ask students to find (a) the genre, (b) who they are writing to, (c) what they must state and support. Point out that the question names the reader (the President of the PTA) but not the writer — so the writer is a PTA member, a parent or a teacher, and the tone should be a concerned one.*

2. Task analysis

Genre	Formal letter
Target audience	*a letter from a member of the PTA to the President of the PTA*
Purpose of writing	*to state clearly whether you are for or against the four-day week, and to give reasons that support your view*
Style and tone	*formal, persuasive and sincere; the tone of a concerned parent or teacher*
Text-type features (opening and closing)	*greeting 'Dear Mr / Ms …' — no name is given in the question, so invent one (e.g. Mr Chan); state your stance in the opening; sign off 'Yours sincerely,' + your name (use 'Chris Wong' unless a name is given)*
Word guide	*Part B: about 400 words (Part A is the shorter task). Stay within the space given.*

3. Build your idea bank

Your letter needs to say WHO benefits and HOW. Fill in the table with as many reasons as you can, then keep the three strongest ones.

Who is affected?	Reasons FOR a four-day week	Reasons AGAINST a four-day week
Students		
Teachers and other school staff		
The school (management)		
Parents and family life		

Idea bank — possible answers (any three, well explained, will do):

FOR: Students — more time for ECAs, rest, hobbies and socialising; less stress; a real weekend. Teachers and staff — a free weekday for professional development, rest, family, less burnout. The school — the extra hour each day can be used as a buffer for remedial and enhancement classes; better use of facilities; fewer absentees. Parents — more time with their children; less pressure to arrange supervision. AGAINST: Students — longer days mean fatigue and weaker concentration, especially in the last lesson; less time for ECAs after school. Teachers and staff — childcare and commuting problems; workload is not reduced by a longer day. The school — timetabling and supervision are difficult; after-school activities clash with the longer day. Parents — supervision and childcare on the free day; disruption to family routines.

4. Your writing plan

Plan your own letter before you read someone else's. One line each is enough — you will come back to this plan in Part 3.

Greeting	*Dear Mr Chan,*
Opening paragraph	*purpose • your stance • the three points you will cover*
Main body	
Closing paragraph	
Closing	*Yours sincerely, / Chris Wong*

PART 2: READ THE SAMPLE — WHAT IT DOES WITH CONTENT AND ORGANISATION (30 minutes)

A. The sample script (Level 5),** *transcribed. Crossed-out words are left out and the writer's own corrections are kept, so this is the version the marker read. The original handwritten script is on the screen.*

[1] Dear Mr. Wong,

[2] I am writing to you to express my opinion for the implementation of a four-day school week proposed by the School Management. It is an indisputable fact that almost all primary to secondary educational institutions across Hong Kong have adopted the five school days a week pattern for students for over many generations. Nonetheless, the debate of cutting the fifth school day in the week, merging with the weekends distributing one hour to the other respective school days is gaining momentum, as the one extra valid day would potentially benefit

various stakeholders of the school. In my opinion, this novel pattern of school days is conducive to the students, the school and also the parents.

[3] First, students can achieve a holistic personal development with the four-day school week. The issue of learners in the school being only skilled in taking examinations and studying while overlooking the importance of developing an interest in other extra-curricular activities is always what parents are apprehensive towards. Though this is not done by the school or parents deliberately, students often struggle to choose between using the weekends to do what they like or spend time to prepare for the next test. With Hong Kong's education system being immensely exam-oriented, affecting the future of students, many learners are left with no choice but to choose the latter. Because of this, students may lose their valuable opportunities to develop essential social skills, discover their own true interests and create bonds between peers. So, the one extra day pattern can provide students with more time to try out different kinds of indoor and outdoor activities, from sports to creating art works to playing music. Parents can also use the one extra day to apply for classes that teach the interests of their children. Since that day is already marked as vacant, students do not need to go to the classes after a tiring school day and could spend that day concentrating on their beloved activities and talents. In addition, the extra one day in the weekend can give learners more freedom to meet up with their friends and spend time together, such as watch a movie and so much more. This can alleviate their stress from school through socializing and doing sports. Eventually, with the lengthened weekend, students are able to acquire vital social skills while having a better chance to flourish their talents and generate a stronger bond with their peers using the extra day provided. In a word, the four days school week can help students to achieve all-rounded excellence.

[4] Second, schools can use the extra hours of each school day to lay down plans for students, which can help them achieve academic excellence. Without a doubt, the education system in Hong Kong is fully driven by exams, along with public exams like the DSE which determines the future of each learner. So, schools always splurge a larger sum of money and resources on providing students with remedial classes, tutorial classes and enhancement classes that are hosted by professionals outside the school in order to help learners catch up with their subjects or enhance their exam performance. Therefore, the extra one hour in the school days can let the schools use it as a buffer for students and teachers to either set extra classes in case the class is falling behind, or host a wide variety of enhancement classes to train students for the future examination and develop useful examination skills, building students' confidence and this is very integral to students too. Moreover, the extra one day of the weekend is also one free day for the teachers and other employers of the school. They could also use the extra day to relieve the stress from work by doing what they like and take a breather. In short, the four day school week can shoulder the responsibility of the school from catching up with the progress, help the students who are in dire need and boost their performance, and also give teachers more time to relax.

[5] Third, the extra day can foster relationship between the parents and their child. The usual 5 days school week, with about 8-9 hours of mandatory lesson time each means parents can spend the day working without the need to worry about their children as they are under schools' supervision. However, that also means after exhausting day of work for parents, sometimes parents return home at midnight in

which even the dinner is finished by children themselves or their maid. This comes down to both not having sufficient time to spend doing activities together. To add insult to injury, family issues are often stemmed from lack of communication between parents and children, or lack of care towards the sons and daughters. Therefore, the extra day can be a great opportunity for parents to spend time with their beloved child through doing a multitude of activities together, such as going on a hiking together, shopping together, playing games together and many more. By this, parents can live up to the role of guiding their children through difficulties and giving them unconditional love, as well as having the chance to rejuvenate their relationship if it is estranged. So, the four days school week is conducive to the parents of the students, who are also a part and parcel to a school's integrity.

[6] All in all, the four days school week can give students more freedom to achieve their own greatness, give school a convenient window to suit every student's needs, and a silver bullet for the students' parents to build a lovable family. I believe the implication of cutting one school day and adding other school days with one hour is highly possible, and have every stakeholder of the school to reap benefits from it.

[7] Yours sincerely,
Mr. Smith

Transcription note for you: *a few words in the handwritten script are only partly legible. In [4] the phrase after 'the extra' is hard to read (it may be a number word); the reading here follows your slide. Everything else is as written.*

B. Read for the gist (3 minutes)

1. Who is writing, and to whom?

2. Is the writer FOR or AGAINST the proposal? Write down the sentence that tells you.

3. One sentence each: what does paragraph [3] say students gain? What does paragraph [4] say the school gains? What does paragraph [5] say parents gain?

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Key: *1. A member of the PTA (a parent/teacher, signing as 'Mr. Smith') writes to the President of the PTA, Mr Wong. 2. FOR. 'In my opinion, this novel pattern of school days is conducive to the students, the school and also the parents.' (also 'the one extra valid day would potentially benefit various stakeholders of the school'). 3. [3] students gain a holistic personal development — time for interests, ECAs, social skills and rest. [4] the school gains academic excellence and teachers gain time to relax. [5] parents gain family time and a closer relationship with their children.*

C. CONTENT — which ideas, and how are they made convincing?

Task 1. Look back at your idea bank in Part 1. Tick every idea that the sample writer also used. Then write down ONE good idea of yours that the writer did NOT use — could you add it?

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Task 2. Complete the content map for the three body paragraphs.

Paragraph	Who benefits	The writer's main point (one sentence)	What supports the point (tick in the sample: an explanation of WHY it happens / a concrete example or comparison / a factual detail about Hong Kong / a reference to the other side)
[3]			
[4]			
[5]			

Key: *[3] students — a four-day week lets them develop holistically (interests, ECAs, social skills) instead of spending every weekend on tests. Supports: explains WHY (exam-oriented system → no choice but to study; loss of opportunities), concrete examples (sports, art, music, watching a film, interest classes), reference to the other side ('Though this is not done by the school or parents deliberately…'). [4] the school and its teachers — the extra hour each day can be used to support weaker students and to train exam skills, while teachers gain a breather. Supports: Hong Kong factual detail (DSE, remedial/tutorial/enhancement classes paid for outside school, money and resources), explanation of WHY, and the counter-case of the usual 5-day week being a supervision service. [5] parents and family life — the free day creates time together and repairs relationships. Supports: a concrete comparison (8–9 hour days, parents home at midnight, dinner finished, the maid), a candid look at the other side ('However, that also means…'), examples (hiking, shopping, games), and a strong closing sentence that returns to the point.*

Task 3. Content that scores 7. The writer does four things. Find and copy the evidence for each one from the sample.

What the writer does	Evidence from the sample (copy the words)
(a) Answers the whole question: states an opinion AND gives reasons	*[2] 'I am writing to you to express my opinion for the implementation of a four-day school week' + [3]–[5] each give reasons*
(b) Explains the cause, not just the benefit	*[3] 'Though this is not done by the school or parents deliberately, students often struggle to choose…' / 'With Hong Kong's education system being immensely exam-oriented… many learners are left with no choice but to choose the latter.' / 'Because of this, students may lose their valuable opportunities…'*
(c) Uses concrete, Hong Kong-specific detail	*[4] 'remedial classes, tutorial classes and enhancement classes that are hosted by professionals outside the school'; 'public exams*

	like the DSE'; [5] 'parents return home at midnight in which even the dinner is finished by children themselves or their maid'
(d) Shows he knows the other side, then answers it	*[3] 'Though this is not done by the school or parents deliberately…'; [5] 'However, that also means after exhausting day of work for parents…'*

Why does (d) — answering the other side — matter to the marker?

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Key: *it shows the writer can see the issue from more than one side, so the argument sounds balanced and mature instead of one-sided. HKEAA's 2022 briefing on this question says a letter 'may present rebuttals to his/her argument and refute them' — not compulsory, but it adds interest and weight.*

D. ORGANISATION — how the sample is built

Task 4. Label every move in the letter. Choose from the move bank and write the move in the last column.

Move bank: *• Greeting (salutation) • Purpose of writing + your stance • 'Road map': the three points the letter will cover • Point 1 — benefit to students • Point 2 — benefit to the school and its teachers • Point 3 — benefit to parents / family life • Summary of the three points + what the writer hopes will happen • Sign-off*

Move	Paragraph	What the writer is doing (choose from the move bank)
1	[1]	*Greeting (salutation)*
2	[2]	*Purpose of writing + your stance (and a 'road map' of the three points)*
3	[3]	*Point 1 — benefit to students*
4	[4]	*Point 2 — benefit to the school and its teachers*
5	[5]	*Point 3 — benefit to parents / family life*
6	[6] and [7]	*Summary of the three points*

		+ what the writer hopes will happen + sign-off

Task 4b. Look at paragraphs [3], [4] and [5]. Each one ends with a sentence that repeats the point of the paragraph (a 'round-off'). Copy the round-off sentence of [4] and explain why an examiner likes it.

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Key: *'In short, the four day school week can shoulder the responsibility of the school from catching up with the progress, help the students who are in dire need and boost their performance, and also give teachers more time to relax.' It closes the paragraph by naming all three benefits of that paragraph (school progress, weaker students, teachers) in parallel form, so the marker can see the paragraph is complete and the point has been pushed home.*

Task 5. The topic sentences

Copy the first sentence of paragraphs [3], [4] and [5] into the table, then answer the questions below.

Paragraph	Topic sentence
[3]	*First, students can achieve a holistic personal development with the four-day school week.*
[4]	*Second, schools can use the extra hours of each school day to lay down plans for students, which can help them achieve academic excellence.*
[5]	*Third, the extra day can foster relationship between the parents and their child.*

What do all three topic sentences have in common? *(Think: how does each one begin? Whose benefit does each one promise?)*

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Which sentence in the closing paragraph 'mirrors' the three topic sentences? Copy it.

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Key: *each begins with a sequencing linker (First / Second / Third) and then names WHO benefits and WHAT they gain — one paragraph, one stakeholder, one benefit. Mine: 'All in all, the four days school week can give students more freedom to achieve their own greatness, give school a convenient window to suit every student's needs, and a silver bullet for the students' parents to build a lovable family' — the same three stakeholders in the same order (students → school → parents), which is what makes the letter feel organised. Accept any well-formed extra topic sentence, e.g. 'Fourth, the extra day can give the school a chance to review its timetable for the benefit of every class.'*

Task 6. Linking words — where they are, and how to improve them

(a) Find every sentence that begins with a linking word and put the linking word into the right box.

Adding more	**Sequencing**	**Contrasting**	**Cause and effect**	**Summarising**
In addition, Moreover	*First, Second, Third*	*Nonetheless, However, Though*	*Therefore, Because of this, So, Eventually*	*In a word, In short, All in all*

(b) Our marker's comment on this script was 'mainly sentence-initial linking words'. Rewrite each sentence so that the linking word moves inside the sentence. The first one is done for you.

Sentence with a sentence-initial linker	**Your rewrite**
Therefore, students will be able to develop their own talents.	*Students will therefore be able to develop their own talents.*
However, parents will find it hard to spend time with their children.	*Parents will, however, find it hard to spend time with their children. (or: While parents will find it hard to spend time with their children, they can …)*
In addition, teachers can use the free day for professional development.	*Teachers can, in addition, use the free day for professional development. (or: Teachers can also use the free day …)*

(c) One more organisation fault to notice: paragraph [3] is about 250 words long. Where would you split it into two paragraphs, and why?

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***Key:** a natural split is after '…create bonds between peers.' — the first half is about what students LOSE (the problem), the second half about what the free day GIVES them (the solution). Splitting long body paragraphs is a cheap organisation mark: a reader can follow one paragraph, one idea.*

E. LANGUAGE — words and patterns worth stealing (10 minutes, or homework)

Task 7. Read each word or phrase and study how the writer uses it in the sample sentence. Then do the writing task at the end.

Word / phrase	**What it means**	**The sentence in the sample**
indisputable	cannot be argued against; certain	It is an indisputable fact that almost all primary to secondary educational institutions across Hong Kong have adopted…
gaining momentum	becoming stronger / more widely supported	the debate of cutting the fifth school day in the week … is gaining momentum
stakeholders	the people who are involved and affected	the one extra valid day would potentially benefit various stakeholders of the school
conducive to	helpful to / good for	this novel pattern of school days is conducive to the students, the school and also

		the parents
alleviate	make (pain or stress) less severe	This can alleviate their stress from school through socializing and doing sports.
integral	very important (to something)	building students' confidence and this is very integral to students too
in dire need	needing help very much	help the students who are in dire need
splurge (on)	spend a lot of money (on)	schools always splurge a larger sum of money and resources on providing students with…
live up to the role of	do what the role expects of you	parents can live up to the role of guiding their children through difficulties
part and parcel of	an essential part of	parents … are also a part and parcel to a school's integrity
a silver bullet	a simple, instant solution to a problem	and a silver bullet for the students' parents to build a lovable family
reap benefits	gain advantages	every stakeholder of the school (can) reap benefits from it

Two patterns from the sample:

Pattern A: *It is an indisputable fact that + statement.* It is an indisputable fact that almost all schools have adopted the five-day school week for generations.

Pattern B: *With + situation + being + description, + someone + is left with no choice but to + verb.* With Hong Kong's education system being immensely exam-oriented, many learners are left with no choice but to choose the latter.

Task 8. Use FOUR items from the table and BOTH patterns to write TWO sentences about the four-day school week.

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PART 3: COMMENT, SCORE AND WRITE (15 minutes)

1. Your comments and scores on the sample

Tick the criteria you can prove from the text, and write the evidence in the last column.

Criterion	What to look for	Evidence from the sample	Score
Content:	All task requirements fulfilled / Good arguments / Good elaboration		/ 7

Language:	Accurate grammar / Good variety of vocabulary & structures / Right style and formality		/ 7
Organisation:	Good flow of ideas / Good paragraphing / Coherent opening & closing paragraphs		/ 7

2. The real marks

Three markers marked this script. Their marks:

Criterion	Marker 1	Marker 2	Third marker	Final (out of 7)
Content	7	6	7	7
Language	7	5	6	6
Organisation	6	5	6	6
Total				18.3 / 21 (≈ 87% → Level 5**)

Discussion: Which two criteria carried this script to a 5**? Where do you think marks were lost?

Key: *The script earns full or near-full Content marks because it fulfils every task requirement and elaborates each argument; Organisation is a little lower — the paragraphing is clear (opening, three body paragraphs, closing) and the topic sentences are strong, but the body paragraphs are over-long and the linking words are almost all sentence-initial. Language is the lowest of the three: the vocabulary and structures are ambitious, but there are slips (missing articles, wrong word forms, over-long sentences). Content and Organisation together are 14 of the 21 marks.*

3. Even a 5** script is not perfect

These lines are taken from the sample. Correct each one.

Line from the sample	Your correction
The usual 5 days school week, with about 8-9 hours of mandatory lesson time …	*The usual five-day school week, with about 8-9 hours of mandatory lesson time … (compound adjective: five-day, not '5 days')*
So, the four days school week is conducive to the parents of the students …	*So, the four-day school week is conducive to the parents of the students …*
… students are able to acquire vital social skills while have a better chance to flourish their talents …	*… students are able to acquire vital social skills while having a better chance to flourish their talents … (after 'while', use the –ing form)*
Third, the extra day can foster relationship between the parents and their child.	*Third, the extra day can foster a closer relationship between the parents and their child. ('a/an + adjective + singular noun')*
I believe the implication … is highly possible, and have every stakeholder of the school to	*I believe the implication … is highly possible, and that every stakeholder of the school will*

reap benefits from it.	*reap benefits from it. (parallel clause)*

4. Your turn

Write the opening paragraph of your own letter (4–5 sentences). Use the plan you made in Part 1.

> *Greeting • I am writing to … (say what you are writing about) • your stance • tell the reader the three points you will cover*
>
> *Use at least one pattern or word from the 'steal these' table.*

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5. What to take away

Content, Language and Organisation are 7 marks each in Part B. This script used its **ideas** and the **way they were arranged** to reach a 5** — 14 of its 21 marks — even though its grammar slips. Great writers at Level 5** make sure that (1) every requirement in the question is answered, (2) every reason is explained, not just listed, and (3) the reader always knows which point belongs to which paragraph.

Homework / next lesson:

1. Finish the paragraph in Part 3 (opening paragraph of your own letter). 2. Write the topic sentences of your three body paragraphs, using the pattern from Task 5 (sequencing word + who benefits + what they gain). 3. Complete the 'steal these' sentences from Task 8.

What HKEAA said about this question (2022 briefing for teachers):

'Introduction — Salutation/Greeting; Stance. Body — Supporting arguments/counter-argument. Closing. The letter should provide clearly stated points that are relevant to the discussion of schools adopting a four-day week instead of five. Candidates may present rebuttals to his/her argument and refute them (not necessary to do both). Tone of a concerned parent or teacher would add more interest to the points given.' It was also the most popular elective question in Part B in 2022 (mean 57.9%). Useful if a student asks what the examiner is looking for.

Design note: *your original handout had Task Analysis → Writing plan → Sample → comments/scores. The tasks C1–C3 (content) and D4–D6 (organisation) are the new middle of the lesson: they are what makes students read the sample as a model of CONTENT and ORGANISATION, not only as a source of vocabulary. If 60 minutes is tight, your order of priority is D4 (moves) → D5 (topic sentences) → C2 (content map); part E can go home.*